

THE LATE DR. ABDURRAHMAN MORA (1916–1997): A DISTINGUISHED EDUCATIONIST, DIPLOMAT, AND PUBLIC SERVANT

The late Dr. Abdurrahman Mora (1916–1997) was one of Northern Nigeria's most accomplished educationists, administrators, diplomats, and public servants. Throughout his distinguished career, he made significant contributions to education, public administration, diplomacy, and Islamic scholarship, leaving a legacy that continues to inspire future generations.

Early Life and Education

Born in 1916, Dr. Abdurrahman Mora belonged to the pioneering generation of highly educated Northern Nigerians. By 1946, he was regarded as one of the first four most educated Northerners of his era, alongside the late Sir Abubakar Tafawa Balewa, Nigeria's first and only Prime Minister; Mallam Yahaya Gusau (*Shettiman Sokoto*); and Mallam Bello Kano (*Madakin Kano*).

He attended Katsina Higher College, Katsina (1933–1938), one of the foremost educational institutions in Northern Nigeria. In 1945–1946, he furthered his education at the Institute of Education, University of London, United Kingdom.

His educational achievements were exceptional. He obtained:

- Katsina Higher College Certificate (1938);
- Professional Teachers' Certificate, Institute of Education, University of London (1946);
- Senior Teachers' Certificate in Geography from Wolsey Hall, England (1952), passed at his first attempt; and
- American State Department Fellowship at Iowa State Teachers College, Cedar Falls, USA (1952–1953).

In 1952, he became the first Northern Nigerian to receive an American State Department Fellowship under the United States Information Service (USIS). During the six-month programme, he joined about 300 teachers from 49 countries, studying at Iowa State Teachers College and visiting several American cities, including Chicago, New York, New Hampshire, and Connecticut. His report, *Teacher Training Fellowships in the United States of America (1952–1953)*, reflected the knowledge and experience he gained during the fellowship.

Career in Education

Dr. Mora began his teaching career at Zaria Middle School in 1938. Between 1947 and 1950, he taught at Kaduna College (later Barewa College), Northern Nigeria's premier public secondary school.

He served as:

- Headmaster, Zaria Middle School (1950–1954);
- Provincial Education Officer for Zaria Province (from 1954), one of the first ten appointed in Northern Nigeria;
- Adult Education Officer, Northern Region Headquarters, Kaduna (1955–1959); and
- Sole Inspector of Adult Education for the entire Northern Region.

He played a leading role in strengthening educational administration and is widely credited with introducing the Parent-Teacher Association (PTA) concept into Northern Nigerian schools during the mid-1950s.

He was also active in professional educational organisations, serving as:

- Assistant Secretary, Northern Teachers' Association (1948);
- Secretary-General, Northern Teachers' Association (1950);
- Member, Northern Regional Board of Education;
- Member, Northern Nigerian Moral Standards Committee;
- Member, Executive Committee of the Northern Regional Boys' Scout Council;
- Member, Central Board of Education, Lagos; and
- Member, West African Examinations Council (WAEC).

Public Service and Diplomatic Career

Dr. Mora later joined the Northern Regional Civil Service, where he served in several senior administrative positions before being seconded to the Federal Government.

His distinguished appointments included:

- Pilgrims Officer and Chargé d'Affaires at the Nigerian Embassy in Jeddah, Saudi Arabia;
- First Secretary following the establishment of diplomatic relations between Nigeria and Saudi Arabia;
- Nigeria's High Commissioner to the Islamic Republic of Pakistan (1967–1971);
- Permanent Secretary, Federal Ministry of Lagos Affairs; and
- Permanent Secretary, Federal Ministry of Internal Affairs.

These appointments reflected the confidence successive governments placed in his administrative competence and diplomatic abilities.

Scholarship and Literary Contributions

Dr. Mora authored at least seventeen pamphlets on Islam and Geography from an Islamic perspective. He also edited *Abubakar Imam Memories* (1989), a biography of his close friend and father-in-law, the late Dr. Abubakar Imam, OBE, CON, LLD.

Educational Legacy

Education remained central to the Mora family's tradition.

Several generations of the family attended Barewa College, while 42 children and grandchildren studied at Ahmadu Bello University (ABU), Zaria, producing professionals in medicine, pharmacy, law, accounting, and other disciplines.

Members of the family have also contributed extensively to teaching and academia, including professors, medical specialists, pharmacists, and other educators.

Community and Religious Service

Following his retirement in 1971, Dr. Mora devoted himself to religious instruction in his residence at 23/25 Mora Road, Tudun Wada, Zaria. Under his guidance, 59 children from his household and neighbouring families successfully completed the recitation of the Holy Qur'an.

He also remained active in educational development.

In 1980, he chaired the Kaduna State Committee on the Restoration of Discipline in Secondary Schools.

In 1983, he became Chairman of the Governing Council of the College of Arts and Science (now Nuhu Bamalli Polytechnic), Zaria.

Between 1981 and 1988, he served as Chairman of the Parent-Teacher Association of Government Girls Secondary School, Soba.

In 1992, he became the inaugural Chairman of the Board of Trustees of the Zaria Educational Development Association (ZEDA), Northern Nigeria's first community-based educational development association of its kind.

Passing and Legacy

Dr. Abdurrahman Mora passed away on 19 May 1997 after a lifetime devoted to education, public service, diplomacy, scholarship, and community development.

His enduring legacy is reflected in the thousands of students he influenced, the educational institutions he strengthened, the public offices he served with distinction, and the generations of professionals he inspired through his family and personal example.

May Allah (SWT) forgive his shortcomings, accept his good deeds, and grant him the highest place in Aljannah Firdaus. Ameen.